

# Inspection toolkit for education, skills and work activities in prisons and young offender institutions

This toolkit sets out the areas that will be evaluated and graded by Ofsted's further education and skills inspectors when they inspect education, skills and work activities in prisons and young offender institutions in England, as part of joint inspections led by His Majesty's Inspectorate of Prisons (HMIP). These reports contribute to the section on 'purposeful activity' in the HMIP inspection reports.

The toolkit can also be used by leaders to support self-evaluation and continuous improvement.

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# Gathering evidence

This inspection toolkit is based on statutory duties, non-statutory guidance, professional standards, research and inspection evidence. We will update it as required, usually on an annual basis, to reflect any changes.

Inspectors focus on the impact of the systems and processes that leaders use to support the continuous improvement and effective running of the prison's or young offender institution (YOI)'s education, skills and work curriculum.

Inspectors collect first-hand evidence of how the prison typically operates education, skills and work, mainly through professional conversation and joint inspection activity, often alongside leaders, to observe the day-to-day work of the purposeful activity. Inspectors are required to view specific documentation. This should be limited to documents that the prison and its contractors produce as part of their normal business processes. Inspectors do not need information to be presented in any specific format, as long as it is easily accessible. We do not need leaders to produce documents specifically for an Ofsted inspection.

Inspectors will be proportionate in weighing up the evidence they gather, balancing the extent of any strengths or priorities for improvement in each of the evaluation areas. This will support grading and allow specific features of practice, whether strengths or priorities for improvement, to be reported clearly.

In addition to the evaluation areas set out in this toolkit, inspectors will consider HMIP's [Expectations for different types of detention](#). These are for men's prisons, women's prisons and for children in custody.

## Supporting evidence for the toolkit

We have published the statutory and non-statutory guidance, professional standards and relevant research that we reviewed to inform and develop the education inspection toolkits.

See the list of references: [Renewed education inspection framework: supporting evidence base](#).

Alternatively, scan the QR code below to see the full list of references:



# Inclusion

This evaluation area considers how leaders and staff identify, assess and support the needs of prisoners to enable them to participate and progress in education, training and work. This includes prisoners in one or more of the following groups:

- prisoners with additional needs, such as special educational needs and/or disabilities (SEND), including needs related to neurodiversity; within this group are prisoners receiving SEND support and those who have an education, health and care (EHC) plan (or individual development plan for prisoners from Wales) in the community
- prisoners who need to learn to read or improve their reading
- (YOIs only) disadvantaged children – the term 'disadvantaged' refers to children who have been eligible for free school meals or pupil premium funding in the past 6 years
- prisoners who are known (or previously known) to social care, such as those who are under the age of 18 and in care, or care leavers
- prisoners experiencing mental health difficulties; their support may be offered through the assessment, care in custody and teamwork (ACCT) process or another prison/YOI support process
- prisoners with limited English language knowledge, because it is not their first language
- prisoners who have experienced significant challenges and/or traumatic events in their personal lives, such as those who have been subject to domestic abuse
- prisoners who are deemed to be at risk due to the nature of their offence, are self-isolating or otherwise separated from their peers, such as those living in a segregation unit or equivalent
- prisoners with substance misuse problems, or other health challenges
- younger prisoners in adult prisons, such as those who have moved from a YOI into the adult estate
- prisoners who are pregnant and/or have a young child with them in prison
- prisoners who face any other barriers to their education, skills and work, including as the result of a protected characteristic; those who were previously not in employment, education or training (NEET), in particular at YOIs; or those who need to improve their functional English and mathematics skills (based on entry points)

Inspectors focus on the factors that professional standards, non-statutory guidance, research and inspection evidence indicate contribute most strongly to inclusion.

These factors are:

- setting high expectations for all prisoners, in particular those who face barriers to accessing and succeeding in education, skills and work
- establishing a culture in which early and accurate assessment of prisoners' needs is prioritised
- reducing barriers to prisoners' ability to access and make progress in education, training and/or work through targeted and effective support, and timely review of this support, using expertise from across the prison
- ensuring that prisoners' views and aspirations are included in decision-making about the support they receive

# Considering inclusion in different types of prison

When inspectors apply this evaluation area, they:

- consider the contexts in which different types of prison and YOI operate (such as the varying ages of prisoners, their lengths of stay and sentence, the types of offence, the proportions of prisoners who are sentenced/being held on remand, and the categories of prisoner), how these factors might present barriers to education, training and work for prisoners and how leaders take account of this in their approach to inclusion
- seek to understand whether leaders' and staff's assessment and identification of the starting points of individual prisoners are accurate; this includes prisoners with SEND (including those with needs related to neurodiversity) and those who need to learn to read or develop their reading
- keep in mind that, while there is no requirement for this, it is likely that a member of staff, such as a neurodiversity manager, will lead on support for prisoners with SEND (including those with needs related to neurodiversity) and other barriers to learning; where such a member of staff has been appointed, inspectors will work with them during the inspection

# Gathering evidence about inclusion

## Identifying and assessing needs, and reducing barriers

In gathering evidence about identifying, assessing and reducing barriers, inspectors evaluate the extent to which leaders:

- have established a culture in which staff throughout the prison understand the range of barriers that prisoners may face to accessing and succeeding in education, skills and work, including those specific to their context, and they work quickly and accurately to identify prisoners who are facing those barriers
- make sure those who face barriers to education, skills and work receive effective support and that appropriate reasonable adjustments are made in accordance with the [Equality Act 2010](#) and, where relevant, the [SEND code of practice](#)
- make sure that workplace and classroom settings, including any external settings, are suitable and safe and meet prisoners' abilities and needs, including any support requirements they may have

## Supporting prisoners with SEND (including needs related to neurodiversity)

In gathering evidence about supporting prisoners with SEND (including needs related to neurodiversity), inspectors evaluate the extent to which leaders:

- have an appropriately experienced manager or coordinator, for example a neurodiversity manager, who ensures that the prison's wider support is effective in making a positive difference for prisoners with SEND (including needs related to neurodiversity), and draws on specialists where necessary
- ensure that their work improves the progress and attainment of prisoners with SEND (including needs related to neurodiversity), and that they do not lower their expectations of them
- meet the needs of prisoners with SEND (including needs related to neurodiversity), making reasonable adjustments to the environment and the prison's wider offer that help to ensure that these prisoners access education, training and work
- work effectively with external partners, such as local authorities, to ensure those with SEND (including those with needs related to neurodiversity and those with an EHC plan in the community) receive the support they need while in custody, and that their progress is reviewed appropriately

## Supporting prisoners who need to learn to read or improve their reading

In gathering evidence about supporting prisoners who need to learn to read or improve their reading, inspectors evaluate the extent to which leaders:

- have an ambitious strategy to improve prisoners' reading
- assess prisoners' starting points effectively, and monitor their progress
- design and implement effective and age-appropriate reading interventions

## Supporting disadvantaged children (YOIs only)

In gathering evidence about supporting disadvantaged children, inspectors evaluate the extent to which leaders in YOIs:

- have a secure understanding of their needs and use appropriate evidence to inform their approaches to addressing these
- continually monitor the impact of their approaches, including their inclusion strategy and any associated strategies and policies, and make helpful and proactive adaptations as appropriate
- ensure that their approaches, including to their inclusion strategy and any associated strategies and policies, have a positive impact on children's achievement and/or wellbeing

## Supporting prisoners who are known (or previously known) to social care

In gathering evidence about supporting prisoners who are known (or previously known) to social care teams, inspectors evaluate the extent to which leaders in YOIs:

- ensure that prisoners who are looked-after children or care leavers, whether they are sentenced or unsentenced, receive high-quality support to improve their progress and attainment; this includes leaders and staff having regard to personal education plans, if any are in place
- share information with the local authority, including for statutory assessments of children's social care needs
- work with social workers, personal advisers and other professionals to provide effective multi-agency planning and support for their engagement and progress in education, skills and work

## Supporting prisoners who face other barriers to education, skills and work

In gathering evidence about supporting prisoners who are facing other barriers to accessing and succeeding in education, skills and work, inspectors evaluate the extent to which leaders:

- identify prisoners' emerging and changing needs quickly and accurately, using specialist support and expertise from across the prison to assess, plan, implement and review support for prisoners in a way that is effective in meeting their needs, and ensure that staff receive suitable training and support to implement this approach successfully
- sensitively approach prisoners to offer support to ensure that they can continue with their education or work and maintain their wellbeing
- use their knowledge of prisoners to inform decisions about promoting their welfare and/or supporting them to maintain their wellbeing
- are alert to prisoners' emerging and changing needs and can quickly identify those who are at risk of not attending or engaging in education, skills and work
- make sure that the delivery of their inclusion strategy, and any associated strategies and policies, is sustained and monitored effectively
- have access to specialist organisations that support them in reducing barriers that prisoners face, and work with those organisations where appropriate

## Grading inclusion

| Needs attention                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                  | Expected standard                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                 | Strong standard                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                               |
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| <p><b>Inclusion is likely to be graded 'needs attention' when the expected standard has not been met.</b></p> <p><b>This may include when one or more of the following applies:</b></p> <ul style="list-style-type: none"> <li>• Leaders have only recently started to take appropriate action to identify and assess prisoners' needs and to reduce barriers to accessing and succeeding in education, skills and work.</li> <li>• Leaders mostly take the right actions to support prisoners to access and succeed in education, skills and work, but weaknesses or inconsistencies in providing support have a negative impact on a particular group/groups of prisoners.</li> <li>• Leaders have considered and implemented the training or development that staff require as part of their inclusive approaches, but there are inconsistencies in how well staff put these approaches into practice.</li> <li>• Leaders understand the needs of prisoners but do not share well enough this information with their staff across the establishment, and/or do not monitor closely enough the support they receive. This has a negative impact on these prisoners.</li> </ul> | <p><b>Inclusion meets the 'expected standard' when all the following apply:</b></p> <p>Leaders and staff establish a positive education, skills and work culture in which prisoners' needs are met and, in most cases, prisoners feel supported to fulfil their potential.</p> <p>Leaders and staff quickly and accurately identify prisoners' learning and support needs. They plan, implement and review support for prisoners to ensure that they receive an appropriate level of support which generally meets their needs well.</p> <p>Staff across the establishment receive suitable training to help them provide the support prisoners need to reduce their specific barriers to education, skills and work.</p> <p>Where prisoners face barriers to education, skills and work, leaders take appropriate action for the period of need and do not reduce their high expectations of prisoners.</p> <p>Where the prison has a manager/coordinator responsible for prisoners with SEND, they are appropriately qualified and/or experienced and exercise sufficient leadership to make a positive difference for these prisoners.</p> <p>Leaders have a coherent and ambitious strategy to support prisoners to develop their reading fluency. They provide appropriate interventions</p> | <p><b>Inclusion meets the 'strong standard' when the 'expected standard' has been met and all the following apply:</b></p> <p>Leaders' work on inclusion is embedded in their organisational culture and practices. They establish strategies and staff training that consistently enhance the opportunities and experiences of prisoners, in particular those who face barriers to accessing and succeeding in education, skills and work.</p> <p>Leaders ensure that prisoners' barriers to education, skills and work, including prisoners' development of reading ability, are reduced swiftly and consistently. Staff systematically review and adapt any support, and consistently identify when it is no longer required or can be reduced. This makes a significant difference to prisoners' experiences and opportunities.</p> <p>Leaders carefully monitor the progress of prisoners who face barriers to education, skills and work. They make effective use of relevant data to understand the needs of their prisoners.</p> <p>Leaders make proactive and evidence-informed adaptations to their inclusion strategy, as appropriate, which have a consistently positive impact on prisoners.</p> |

| Needs attention                                                                                                                                                                                                                                   | Expected standard                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                             | Strong standard |
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| <ul style="list-style-type: none"> <li>Leaders have not fully implemented a coherent and ambitious reading strategy, and/or reading interventions. This means that too few prisoners benefit from the reading interventions they need.</li> </ul> | <p>and use appropriate systems which largely meet the needs of prisoners.</p> <p>When prisoners attend external settings for work placements or study, leaders take the necessary steps to make sure these are suitable for prisoners' abilities and needs, including any support requirements they have.</p> |                 |

## Urgent improvement

**Inclusion is likely to be graded 'urgent improvement' when any of the following apply:**

- Leaders do not identify and assess prisoners' needs, and/or identification and assessment do not have a meaningful impact on the provision for prisoners in education, skills and work.
- Leaders do not take into account the barriers prisoners face to accessing and succeeding in education, skills and work and/or do not successfully implement strategies to reduce these barriers.
- Professional learning to help staff identify and support the needs of prisoners with barriers to education, skills and work is limited, is of poor quality and/or has little or no impact on prisoners.
- Leaders' reading strategy has been poorly designed or implemented, and/or has little or no impact on prisoners who need to learn to read or develop their reading.

## Exceptional

**Inspectors may consider leaders' work in inclusion to be 'exceptional' when the 'strong standard' has been met and all the following apply:**

Exceptional standards of inclusion have been sustained over time so that prisoners' barriers to accessing and succeeding in education, skills and work are reduced exceptionally well to ensure highly positive outcomes and experiences.

Leaders' actions have a transformational impact on how well all groups of prisoners engage, achieve and thrive in education, skills and work.

There are no significant areas for improvement that leaders have not already prioritised.

**If this grade is awarded, leaders should use their exceptional success in this evaluation area to:**

- support improvement across all aspects of their own establishment and/or group
- share their learning and best practice externally to support system-wide improvement, for example with other prisons and professionals, their community and stakeholders, including local and/or national networks

# Leadership and governance

This evaluation area considers:

- how leaders (establishment leaders and leaders responsible for education, skills and work) and those responsible for governance and oversight (such as deputy directors for YOIs, prison group directors (PGDs) or equivalent in adult prisons) collectively ensure that the establishment enables every prisoner to engage, achieve and thrive in education, skills and work
- the commitment of leaders and those responsible for governance to raising standards of education, skills and work to improve the lives of all prisoners, in particular those who face barriers to learning and work

Inspectors focus on gathering evidence relating to the factors that statutory and non-statutory guidance, professional standards, research and inspection evidence indicate contribute most strongly to leadership and governance.

These factors are:

- leaders having high expectations of all prisoners, and these being demonstrated by staff in their day-to-day interactions with prisoners
- leaders understanding the strengths and areas for development in education, skills and work, and taking effective and timely action to improve and/or sustain high standards
- leaders and those responsible for governance and/or oversight understanding their respective roles and performing these in a way that enhances the effectiveness of education, skills and work
- leaders ensuring that staff in education, skills and work can access well-planned programmes of professional learning and expertise that meet their needs
- leaders engaging with relevant stakeholders to support prisoners' education, training and work, including, as appropriate, contractors (such as those providing education or careers guidance), employers, community groups, local authorities, social workers, youth justice services, and parents and carers
- those responsible for governance and/or oversight taking into account the workload and wellbeing of leaders and, in turn, leaders taking into account the workload and wellbeing of their staff
- leaders taking decisions and acting in the best interests of prisoners, and prioritising the progress and achievement of prisoners, in particular those who face barriers to accessing and succeeding in education, skills and work

In addition to the evaluation areas set out in this toolkit, inspectors will consider [HMIP's Expectations for different types of detention](#), which are set out for men's prisons, women's prisons and children's custody.

## Considering leadership and governance in different types of prison

When inspectors evaluate leadership and governance across different types of prison, they consider the contexts in which different types of prison and YOIs operate, such as the varying ages of prisoners, their lengths of stay and sentence, the types of offence, the proportions of prisoners who are sentenced/being held on remand and the category of prisoner.

For example, leaders' strategic approaches to developing partnerships and relationships with external stakeholders, such as employers, will vary depending on prison population factors like those outlined above.

Inspectors keep in mind that different establishments may need different approaches. For instance, Youth Custody Service directors will exercise governance and oversight in YOIs, PGDs will oversee adult prisons, and similar roles will apply to private prisons.

# Gathering evidence about leadership and governance

## Strategic leadership

In gathering evidence about strategic leadership, inspectors evaluate the extent to which leaders, including leaders of Prison Education Service provision/other contracted provision:

- have devised and are enacting a clear and ambitious vision, grounded in accurate self-evaluation and aligned to the needs of prisoners and relevant local, regional and/or national skills priorities
- make decisions in the best interests of prisoners, prioritising their experiences, in particular of those who face barriers to education, skills and work, and take a strategic approach to improving the provision, identifying the correct priorities to ensure the best possible outcomes and experiences for prisoners; this should include an ambitious strategy to develop prisoners' reading and strategies to maximise both allocations to and attendance at activities
- forge partnerships with both external and internal stakeholders to inform their planning and enhance opportunities for prisoners
- tailor their approach to the context of the prison and its prisoners
- allocate staffing and resources effectively to build and sustain expertise in education, skills and work, and provide suitable careers guidance to prisoners
- ensure that the prison has sufficient substantial activity spaces for all working-age prisoners, including release on temporary licence (RoTL) opportunities for eligible prisoners such as those in open prisons, and that available spaces are used effectively
- ensure appropriate quality across all education, skills and work, including the quality of contracted provision (such education or careers guidance)
- ensure that the pay policy is fair and incentivises prisoners to make progress in education, skills and work, prioritising English and mathematics, and/or implement other initiatives to incentivise prisoners to make progress in education, skills and work

## Governance

In gathering evidence about governance, inspectors evaluate the extent to which those responsible for oversight:

- ensure that leaders and their teams work towards rectifying the concerns raised at the previous inspection
- provide support and challenge to leaders and hold them to account for prisoners' progress and achievement; this includes all prisoners, in particular those who face barriers to accessing and succeeding in education, skills and work
- understand their role in monitoring leaders' workload and wellbeing, and addressing any issues
- select the most appropriate methods to assure themselves of the quality of provision – including contracted provision such as education and careers guidance – to enable prisoners to engage, achieve and thrive in education, skills and work
- make sure the prison or YOI fulfils its legal duties and responsibilities to ensure the safety of prisoners when attending education, skills and work-related activities

- (YOIs only) ensure that children can access a comprehensive and purposeful day of educational activity
- ensure that leaders allocate resources effectively

## Staff wellbeing and workload

In gathering evidence about staff wellbeing and workload, inspectors evaluate the extent to which leaders:

- take action to ensure that staff's wellbeing is monitored and their workload is manageable
- do not create unnecessary burdens
- protect staff from bullying, unlawful discrimination, harassment and victimisation
- make sure that staff feel valued and are supported to do their jobs to a high standard, ensuring that their time is used as effectively as possible to secure the best outcomes for prisoners

## Professional learning and expertise

In gathering evidence about professional learning and expertise, inspectors evaluate the extent to which:

- leaders establish a culture of continuous improvement, pursuing their own professional learning and expertise and acting as role models for staff
- the prison's professional learning and expertise programme enables education, skills and work staff to meet the demands of each subject/specialist curriculum or work area, including staff who teach and/or instruct outside their subject specialism or work area, and including phonics training for staff to support prisoners with reading
- leaders implement appropriate strategies (including staff training), reasonable adjustments and adaptations to support the needs of all prisoners, in particular those who face barriers to education, skills and work
- leaders provide effective support and development for staff who are new to teaching, training or instructing, and those intending to progress in their careers
- staff continually seek to improve their expertise and maintain a high level of academic, vocational or technical knowledge, drawing on appropriate evidence, the practice of others, links with employers and other relevant stakeholders, and coaching

## Stakeholder engagement

In gathering evidence about stakeholder engagement, inspectors evaluate the extent to which leaders:

- engage with stakeholders, including, as appropriate, prisoners, contractors, local, regional and/or national employers, training and education providers, community groups, other prisons, such as those prisoners are transferred to, and (for children in custody) parents and carers
- have a thorough understanding of potential barriers to high-quality engagement, and work effectively to overcome these
- work effectively with stakeholders in a climate of mutual challenge and support

## Grading leadership and governance

| Needs attention                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                   | Expected standard                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                             | Strong standard                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                    |
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| <p><b>Leadership and governance are likely to be graded 'needs attention' when the expected standard has not been met.</b></p> <p><b>This may include when one or more of the following applies:</b></p> <ul style="list-style-type: none"> <li>• Leaders and those responsible for oversight broadly understand the context of their education, skills and work offer, but their analysis of the strengths and areas for development in education, skills and work lacks precision or does not identify the root causes of issues and find ways to mitigate these.</li> <li>• Leaders and those responsible for oversight demonstrate the capacity to improve, are taking actions to bring about change and are largely focused on the right areas, but their work is not leading to sustainable improvements for prisoners at a swift enough pace.</li> <li>• Those responsible for oversight, while supportive of leaders' ambitions and vision, are inconsistent in the support and challenge they provide. Their approaches to assuring themselves of the impact of leaders' work lack focus.</li> <li>• Leaders' engagement with relevant stakeholders is too limited and/or not</li> </ul> | <p><b>Leadership and governance meet the 'expected standard' when all the following apply:</b></p> <p>Leaders understand the strengths and areas for development in education, skills and work. They largely take appropriate action to drive improvement and sustain high standards, including monitoring progress. Where an aspect of the provision falls short of the expected standard, including contracted provision, this is dealt with effectively.</p> <p>Leaders have taken appropriate action to tackle any concerns in education, skills and work from the previous inspection, which is leading to sustainable improvements for prisoners.</p> <p>Leaders and those responsible for oversight are ambitious for prisoners. They make strategic decisions that are in the best interests of prisoners, in particular those who face barriers to education, skills and work.</p> <p>Leaders and those responsible for oversight collaborate well with stakeholders to enhance prisoners' education, skills and work experiences.</p> <p>Leaders and those responsible for oversight typically manage resources well to provide prisoners with opportunities in education, skills and work, and careers guidance appropriate to their contexts. Those responsible for oversight</p> | <p><b>Leadership and governance meet the 'strong standard' when the 'expected standard' has been met and all the following apply:</b></p> <p>Leaders, governors and those responsible for oversight have a detailed insight into the strengths and areas for development in education, skills and work. This ensures that their strategic priorities are sharply focused, available resources are used highly effectively, and the actions they take have a sustained impact on the quality of education, skills and work.</p> <p>Leaders and those responsible for oversight are tenacious in their pursuit of high standards across education, skills and work. Their excellent insight into what constitutes high-quality education, skills and work, and their high expectations of prisoners are consistently evident across the provision.</p> <p>Leaders and staff forge and maintain lasting partnerships with key stakeholders, which significantly enrich prisoners' experiences in learning and work and maximise their chances of success.</p> <p>Staff benefit consistently from highly tailored and focused programmes of professional learning and expertise that allow them to develop their industry-specific and pedagogical</p> |

| Needs attention                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                  | Expected standard                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                 | Strong standard                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                         |
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| <p>targeted appropriately. It makes a minimal difference to prisoners' learning and work experiences.</p> <ul style="list-style-type: none"> <li>• Leaders are conscious of staff workload, but do not do enough to manage it or to avoid unnecessary burdens.</li> <li>• Leaders provide a programme of professional learning and expertise to staff, but it is overly generic or not well enough targeted. This limits its impact on the quality of the education, skills and work that prisoners receive.</li> <li>• Although leaders and those responsible for oversight have an understanding of the performance of the education contractor, they do not maintain thorough oversight of this, resulting in low-quality provision and experiences for prisoners.</li> <li>• Leaders provide activity spaces for the majority of the sentenced prison population, but there are not sufficient and substantial activity spaces for all sentenced, working-age prisoners to attend education, skills or work activities, including RoTL for eligible prisoners such as those in open conditions.</li> <li>• Although leaders recognise the importance of efficient allocations to activities, they do not ensure that prisoners are allocated swiftly enough, and/or a significant</li> </ul> | <p>support and challenge leaders appropriately, giving due regard to their wellbeing and workload.</p> <p>Leaders ensure that staff feel valued. They consider the wellbeing of staff and make sure workloads are manageable. Leaders protect staff from bullying, unlawful discrimination, harassment, violence and victimisation.</p> <p>Leaders ensure that programmes of professional learning and expertise are generally well planned and implemented and meet the needs of staff.</p> <p>Leaders make sure the prison or YOI fulfils its legal duties and responsibilities to ensure the safety of prisoners when attending education, skills and work-related activities.</p> <p>Leaders ensure that the prison provides sufficient and substantial activity spaces for all sentenced, working-age prisoners to engage in education, skills or work. This includes appropriate RoTL opportunities for eligible prisoners such as those in open conditions. Adult prisoners held on remand also benefit from suitable opportunities to engage in education, skills and work. In YOIs, children access a comprehensive and purposeful day of educational activity.</p> <p>Leaders ensure that prisoner allocations are managed effectively. Only a small number of activity spaces do not have prisoners allocated to them. Prisoners are typically employed in appropriate activities for their needs.</p> | <p>knowledge and skills to a high standard. A culture of continuous improvement is embedded across education, skills and work.</p> <p>Leaders have taken swift and highly impactful action to rectify concerns from the previous inspection. They secure and maintain consistently strong standards across all provision, including that which is contracted, or they are rapidly improving areas where this is not the case.</p> <p>Leaders ensure that prisoner allocations are managed highly effectively. Prisoners are quickly and consistently allocated to education, skills and work activities that meet their needs well.</p> |

| Needs attention                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                  | Expected standard                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                              | Strong standard |
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| <p>proportion of activity spaces do not have prisoners allocated to them.</p> <ul style="list-style-type: none"> <li>• Leaders recognise the importance of prisoners receiving careers guidance relevant to their contexts, but too few prisoners receive this in a timely manner.</li> <li>• Although leaders and those responsible for oversight value the importance of education, skills and work for prisoners' rehabilitation, they do not ensure that available resources are used well enough to provide prisoners with relevant and suitable opportunities in education, skills and work.</li> <li>• Leaders understand the importance of prioritising prisoners' attendance at their education, skills and work activities, but prisoners nevertheless do not typically arrive on time at their activities.</li> </ul> | <p>Leaders and those responsible for oversight ensure that, through appropriate strategic planning, they prioritise prisoners' attendance at their education, skills and work activities. Prisoners can attend their activities and typically arrive on time.</p> <p>The pay policy and/or other initiatives incentivise prisoners to make progress in education, skills and work, in particular with the development of English and mathematics skills and knowledge (including reading).</p> |                 |

## Urgent improvement

### **Leadership and governance are likely to be graded 'urgent improvement' when any of the following apply:**

- Leaders and those responsible for oversight do not identify and/or prioritise the right issues, or take very limited action to deal with these (including contracted education, skills and work). Any actions they have taken have had little or no impact on prisoners' experiences.
- Leaders and those responsible for oversight make poor decisions that have a negative impact on prisoners. These might include, but are not limited to, inappropriate use of contracting or poor use of available resources.
- Leaders do not fulfil their legal duties and responsibilities to ensure the safety of prisoners and staff who are attending education, skills and work-related activities.
- Leaders impose unsustainable workloads on staff, which undermines morale and performance.
- Bullying and harassment in education, skills and work go unnoticed or unchallenged.
- Professional learning and expertise programmes have little or no impact on improving the quality of education, skills and work.
- Leaders provide a very limited number of substantial activity spaces for sentenced, working-age prisoners, including RoTL opportunities for eligible prisoners such as those in open conditions.
- Leaders and their staff do not manage the allocations process effectively. Many activity spaces do not have prisoners allocated to them, or many prisoners engage in activities that do not meet their needs.
- Leaders' weak strategic planning of prisoner movement means that prisoners frequently arrive late to their activities, or do not arrive at all.

## Exceptional

**Inspectors may consider leadership and governance to be 'exceptional' when the 'strong standard' has been met and all the following apply:**

Exceptionally high standards of leadership and governance have been sustained. Leaders, those responsible for oversight, and staff make a strong, positive contribution to the strategic priorities of education, skills and work, leading to continued improvement and/or sustained high standards in all areas.

Leaders and those responsible for oversight have had a transformational impact on the progress and development of all groups of prisoners, in particular those prisoners with specific barriers to education, skills and work.

There are no significant areas for improvement that leaders have not already prioritised.

**If this grade is awarded, leaders should use their exceptional success in this evaluation area to:**

- support improvement across all aspects of their own provision and/or group
- share their learning and best practice externally to support system-wide improvement, for example with other prisons and professionals, their community and stakeholders, including local and/or national networks

# Curriculum, teaching and training

This evaluation area considers:

- how effectively leaders design a high-quality and ambitious education, skills and work offer (including work undertaken on prison wings and commercial workshops) for all prisoners
- how well teachers, trainers and instructors and other staff ensure that the education, skills and work offer (including wing work) is implemented effectively for all prisoners, in particular those who face barriers to education, skills and work

Inspectors focus on the factors that statutory and non-statutory guidance, research and inspection evidence indicate contribute most strongly to curriculum, teaching and training, thereby giving prisoners the greatest possible opportunity to access high-quality education, skills and work.

These factors are:

- having an ambitious education, skills and work offer that reflects the diverse range of starting points and goals that prisoners have in education, skills and work
- teaching and/or training that equips prisoners with the knowledge, skills and behaviours that are essential for their next steps, both in prison (including as they progress to other establishments) and on release
- ensuring that the education, skills and work offer is planned and sequenced so that the end points are clear, and so that it builds on what prisoners already know and can do
- ensuring that teachers, trainers and instructors have expert knowledge and experience of what they teach/instruct
- ensuring that teachers, trainers and instructors teach/instruct the intended education, skills or work curriculum/training programme, presenting information clearly and focusing on the knowledge and concepts that are most important for prisoners to know
- teachers, trainers and staff making effective use of assessment to check prisoners' understanding, and adapting their teaching and training as necessary, ensuring that prisoners fully absorb key concepts and apply their knowledge and skills fluently
- supporting prisoners to reduce their barriers to education, skills and work and to develop the knowledge, skills and behaviours that are essential for their next steps, for example through trained peer mentors

## Considering curriculum, teaching and training in different types of prison

When inspectors evaluate curriculum, teaching and training across different types of prison, they consider the contexts in which different types of prison and YOIs operate, such as the varying ages of prisoners, their lengths of stay and sentence, the types of offence, the proportions of prisoners who are sentenced/being held on remand and the category of prisoner. This may include, for example, whether those with longer stays at the prison have the opportunity to access curriculums at higher levels and/or more challenging work roles, whether prisoners with short stays are equipped with the core skills, knowledge and behaviours they need for their next steps, and whether eligible children in YOIs are supported to access educational opportunities in the community via RoTL.

Inspectors also consider the context of individual curriculums/training, for example:

- the breadth of the curriculum/training and quantity of direct teaching/training/instruction may vary between different education, vocational training and work activities
- the model of delivery that leaders choose, including appropriate peer mentoring, self-directed and/or distance learning, and learning on the job, can vary – Ofsted has no preferred style when it comes to models of delivery

# Gathering evidence about curriculum, teaching and training in different types of prison

## Leadership of curriculum, teaching and training

In gathering evidence about the leadership of curriculum, teaching and training, inspectors evaluate the extent to which leaders:

- have a comprehensive understanding of the education, skills and work offer, and the quality of teaching and training/instructing
- assure themselves that the education, skills and work offer is being taught well
- identify priorities for improvement and take effective and timely action to address these

## Curriculum design to ensure that prisoners gain the knowledge, skills and behaviours to be successful now and in the future

In gathering evidence about the design of the education, skills and work offer to ensure that prisoners gain the knowledge, skills and behaviours to be successful now and in the future, inspectors evaluate the extent to which leaders construct an offer that:

- is ambitious and designed and sequenced appropriately
- reflects the relevant skills needs of the local, regional and national context, as well as career pathways relevant to those leaving custody; for those progressing through custody, it will consider the nature of prisoners' offences and the length of their sentences
- prepares prisoners with the knowledge, skills, and professional behaviours needed for their next steps, including their employability skills, English, English for speakers of other languages (ESOL), mathematical and digital skills, and personal and social development
- enables prisoners to learn to read or develop their reading
- allows enough time for teaching and training, practising and revisiting content, and addressing any gaps in prisoners' knowledge
- includes (where relevant) employers in the design and delivery of the curriculum
- includes (where relevant) work experience and/or work or industry placements via RoTL
- provides work environments that improve prisoners' employability skills

## High-quality teaching, training and learning

In gathering evidence about high-quality teaching and learning, inspectors evaluate the extent to which instructors, trainers and teaching staff:

- are subject experts and (where relevant) have current industry experience and expertise
- communicate and explain up-to-date vocational, academic and technical subject knowledge that reflects expected industry practice and meets employers' needs
- plan learning logically and systematically, sequencing content so that new concepts build on prior learning, and long-term retention of key knowledge is supported

- select the most appropriate teaching and training strategies to maintain prisoners' interest, explain new ideas in ways that prisoners understand, build on their prior knowledge, and maximise learning
- allow time for prisoners to practise and consolidate their learning
- use assessment to check prisoners' understanding, development and progress
- recognise and record prisoners' progress and achievement accurately, taking into account their starting points and prior learning at previous establishments, so that prisoners do not repeat previous learning

## Inclusive curriculum, teaching and training practices

In gathering evidence about inclusive curriculum, teaching and training practices, inspectors evaluate the extent to which leaders ensure that teachers, trainers and instructors:

- recognise prisoners' barriers to education, skills and work, and know how to reduce these
- draw on appropriate evidence to adapt the teaching, training and instruction of the education, skills and work offer for all prisoners, in particular those who face barriers to this
- where appropriate, collaborate with specialists and employers to design and make reasonable adjustments or adaptations to the education, skills and work offer so that it is accessible by all prisoners and supports their progress to their next stage of education, employment and/or training

## Grading curriculum, teaching and training

| Needs attention                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                   | Expected standard                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                              | Strong standard                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                |
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| <p><b>Curriculum, teaching and training are likely to be graded 'needs attention' when the 'expected standard' has not been met.</b></p> <p><b>This may include when one or more of the following applies:</b></p> <ul style="list-style-type: none"> <li>• Leaders' actions to strengthen the education, skills and work offer are at too early a stage of development to see the impact on prisoners' experiences. The offer does not meet prisoners' needs well enough; for example, there is a lack of opportunity to develop skills for future employment.</li> <li>• Leaders' actions to support prisoners with English, ESOL, mathematical and/or digital skills needs do not yet have a sufficiently positive impact.</li> <li>• Leaders recognise the importance of providing prisoners with meaningful opportunities to develop their reading, but their reading offer is not ambitious enough and/or sufficiently well matched to prisoners' needs.</li> <li>• Although teachers, trainers and instructors understand the principles of effective planning for the curriculums/training they deliver, the effectiveness of this planning is</li> </ul> | <p><b>Curriculum, teaching and training meet the 'expected standard' when all the following apply:</b></p> <p>Leaders make sure that the education, skills and work offer is, in the main, relevant to local, regional and national employment and training priorities, prisoners' English, ESOL, mathematical and digital skills needs, and their personal and social development needs. The offer is not based on gender stereotypes.</p> <p>The curriculum includes meaningful opportunities for prisoners learning to read or developing their reading, so they can engage with the wider education, skills and work offer.</p> <p>Leaders ensure that the education, skills and work offer is accessible, allowing prisoners – in particular those who face barriers to participation – to engage well in learning and work.</p> <p>Leaders and their staff ensure that prisoners undertake timely and accurate assessment of their starting points, which take into account their prior learning and achievement.</p> <p>Leaders have largely ensured that subject-level curriculums and training programmes are well sequenced and build on what has already been taught and learned. Teachers, trainers and instructors plan enough time to practise new knowledge and skills, assess progress and</p> | <p><b>Curriculum, teaching and training meet the 'strong standard' when the 'expected standard' has been met and all the following apply:</b></p> <p>Leaders have developed a consistently high-quality offer, with expert teaching and training across courses and training activities. Decisions about what to teach/instruct, when and how are highly effective and tailored to the context of the prison, the activity type and prisoner needs.</p> <p>Leaders ensure that the education, skills and work offer meets employers' and stakeholders' needs and the relevant local, regional and national priorities consistently well. This includes, where relevant, high-quality RoTL opportunities.</p> <p>The education, skills and work offer is regularly updated to support prisoners, based on their needs and goals. It offers significant, meaningful additional learning opportunities and goes beyond the planned outcomes.</p> <p>Within the curriculum, leaders place a high priority on developing prisoners' reading. Reading interventions are highly effective in meeting prisoners' needs.</p> <p>Teachers, trainers and instructors skilfully teach/instruct prisoners in difficult and/or complex topics, connecting new ideas with</p> |

| Needs attention                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                 | Expected standard                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                 | Strong standard                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                         |
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| <p>variable. Curriculums and training plans may not be sequenced well, ambitious enough or fully matched to prisoners' needs.</p> <ul style="list-style-type: none"> <li>• There is some high-quality teaching, training and instructing, but overall the quality of this is variable. In too many cases, teachers, trainers and instructors do not use resources or assessment opportunities well enough, or their explanations of subject knowledge lack clarity.</li> <li>• Although there are positive examples, overall teachers, trainers and instructors do not pay enough attention to developing prisoners' employability skills, both for employment in custody and on release. Education, work and vocational training environments do not enable prisoners to develop these skills sufficiently well.</li> <li>• While some teachers, trainers and instructors are well qualified and experienced, in too many cases they lack the subject knowledge and/or teaching/training skills they need for their roles. This inhibits prisoners' development of new knowledge, skills and behaviours.</li> <li>• Leaders do not routinely make sure that the education, skills and work offer is accessible and/or appropriately adapted for prisoners, in particular those who face barriers to education, skills and work. The</li> </ul> | <p>close any gaps in prisoners' knowledge, skills and behaviours.</p> <p>Teachers, trainers and instructors typically plan useful activities and set prisoners helpful targets to develop their employability skills, both for employment in custody and on release.</p> <p>Teachers, trainers and instructors have the knowledge and skills they need to teach, train and instruct prisoners.</p> <p>Teachers, trainers and instructors generally explain vocational, academic and technical subject knowledge, including subject-specific vocabulary, well. They select appropriate teaching, training and instruction activities and resources to support prisoners' development of new knowledge, skills and behaviours.</p> <p>Teachers, trainers and instructors largely use assessment well to provide constructive feedback to prisoners, and to inform future teaching, training and instructing.</p> <p>Vocational training and work environments typically are appropriate, characteristic of those outside of prison, and improve the employability of prisoners.</p> | <p>existing knowledge so that they can grasp, retain and apply that knowledge automatically and confidently. Teachers, trainers and instructors choose highly effective activities and tasks that are appropriate for the subject and meet prisoners' needs.</p> <p>Prisoners, in particular those who face barriers to education, skills and work, receive high-quality, tailored support, teaching and training. This ensures that they can access and succeed across the full offer. Leaders coordinate specialist support highly effectively, enabling these prisoners to thrive.</p> <p>Vocational training and work environments are consistently representative of those outside of prison. Prisoners have access to high-quality resources to help them develop skills for future employment opportunities.</p> |

| Needs attention                                                                           | Expected standard | Strong standard |
|-------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|-------------------|-----------------|
| reasonable adjustments or adaptations they make are not well matched to prisoners' needs. |                   |                 |

## Urgent improvement

**Curriculum, teaching and training are likely to be graded 'urgent improvement' when any of the following apply:**

- The education, skills and work offer lacks ambition, structure and coherence. Leaders have not considered the curriculum content sufficiently.
- Prisoners with limited English, ESOL, mathematics and/or digital skills and knowledge do not get the teaching, training and support they need to improve.
- The reading offer is of low quality. Many prisoners do not get the support they need to help improve their reading.
- There are fundamental weaknesses in the education, training and instructing that prisoners receive, which leaders have failed to tackle.
- Teachers', trainers' and instructors' expectations of all prisoners, or of specific groups of prisoners, are too low.
- Weak assessment practice means that the teaching and training fail to ensure that prisoners achieve as well as they should.
- Leaders and staff do not identify prisoners' specific and individual needs or make appropriate reasonable adjustments or adaptations to meet them adequately, in particular the needs of prisoners with a specific barrier to accessing and succeeding in education, skills and work.
- Work and vocational training environments are of low quality, and have little or no effect in helping prisoners to develop employability skills.

## Exceptional

**Inspectors may consider leaders' work in curriculum, teaching and training to be 'exceptional' when the 'strong standard' has been met and all the following apply:**

Leaders motivate staff to design and teach/train/instruct an exceptionally high-quality education, skills and work offer that inspires prisoners and promotes their interest and engagement. Teaching, training and instructing across education, skills and work environments enable prisoners to acquire significant new knowledge, skills and behaviours.

Leaders' actions have a transformational impact on the learning and training of all groups of prisoners, in particular those with a specific barrier to accessing and succeeding in education, skills and work. These actions enable prisoners to be fully prepared for their next steps in education, employment and/or training.

There are no significant areas for improvement that leaders have not already prioritised.

**If this grade is awarded, leaders should use their exceptional success in this evaluation area to:**

- support improvement across all aspects of their own provision and/or group
- share their learning and best practice externally to support system-wide improvement, for example with other prisons, professionals, their community and stakeholders, including local and/or national networks

# Achievement

This evaluation area considers the extent to which:

- prisoners develop knowledge, skills and professional behaviours as they progress through the education, skills and work curriculum
- prisoners achieve their individual learning goals and qualifications
- prisoners are ready to progress in education, training or employment, and are equipped to go on to next steps, both in custody and on release, that reflect their interests and personal goals and/or meet their career goals and aspirations
- all prisoners make progress and achieve, in particular those who face barriers to education, skills and work

Inspectors focus on the factors that statutory and non-statutory guidance, research and inspection evidence indicate contribute most strongly to achievement, thereby giving prisoners the greatest possible opportunity to achieve, including through gaining qualifications where appropriate. They focus on what is typical for prisoners in education, skills and work.

These factors are:

- leaders' actions to secure prisoners' development of new knowledge, skills and professional behaviours, relative to their starting points and in relation to the ambitious end points of the prison's education, skills and work curriculum
- leaders' actions to secure prisoners' development of English, ESOL, mathematical and digital skills to help them access learning, make progress towards level 2 mathematics and English qualifications, and take their next steps
- prisoners' (including those in work roles) practical and theoretical work being of a high standard and appropriate to the level they are studying at and/or their job role
- leaders' actions to ensure that prisoners acquire the knowledge, skills and behaviours they need to take their next steps in education, training or employment, both in custody and on release. This includes the development of reading for those prisoners who need to learn to read or improve their reading, and prisoners having relevant personal targets and/or individual learning goals

# Considering achievement in different types of prison

When inspectors evaluate achievement across different types of prison, they consider the progress, attainment and outcomes of prisoners, with reference to the specific nature and needs of the prisoners. They consider the many ways in which progress, attainment and outcomes can be demonstrated, and the varying importance of these to different types of prison and prisoner.

Valuable sources of evidence include:

- qualification achievement rates
- support plan and sentence plan targets
- personal targets for prisoners
- development of new knowledge and skills (including reading and behaviours for employment) against curriculum goals and starting points
- contribution to work activities and standards of work
- progression to positive destinations, both in custody and on release

Inspectors do not review prisons' internal achievement data. To gather evidence for achievement rates, they review data from sources such as prison management information systems and awarding organisations. However, they are likely to discuss with leaders how they use internal data, what it tells them about prisoners' achievement, and the decisions that leaders make as a result.

# Gathering evidence about achievement

## Inclusive achievement: attainment and progress

In gathering evidence about the attainment of qualifications and progress from starting points, inspectors evaluate the extent to which leaders:

- enable prisoners to make substantial and sustained progress from their starting points
- create an environment that supports prisoners to meet their individual learning and work goals and achieve their qualifications
- improve the proportion of prisoners achieving qualifications, or sustain already high achievement rates
- reduce any barriers to education, skills and work so that prisoners achieve their planned outcomes
- check prisoners' progress towards their individual learning goals and qualifications
- enable prisoners with SEND (including needs related to neurodiversity) to develop the knowledge, skills and behaviours they need for success in education and work, including, where relevant, ambitious outcomes such as those in their support and sentence plans

## Inclusive achievement: progress through the curriculum

In gathering evidence about prisoners' development of knowledge, skills and behaviours as they progress through the education, skills and work curriculum, inspectors evaluate the extent to which leaders:

- enable prisoners to gain the knowledge, skills and behaviours outlined in the planned curriculum
- enable prisoners to produce work that consistently meets or exceeds the requirements of their qualifications, individual learning goals, work goals and/or industry standards
- support prisoners to gain the relevant English (including fluency in reading), ESOL, mathematical and digital skills they need for their studies and future progression, both in custody and on release

## Preparation for next steps and release

In gathering evidence about prisoners' preparation for next steps and positive destinations on release, inspectors evaluate the extent to which leaders:

- ensure that prisoners acquire the qualifications, skills and knowledge they need for success in future study and work, both in custody and on release
- ensure that prisoners are fully prepared for their next stage
- support prisoners' progression to positive destinations linked to their studies and/or work
- provide appropriate support to ensure that prisoners have equal opportunities to succeed, including those who face barriers to education, skills and work

# Grading achievement

| Needs attention                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                       | Expected standard                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                 | Strong standard                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                              |
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| <p><b>Achievement is likely to be graded 'needs attention' when the 'expected standard' has not been met.</b></p> <p><b>This may include when one or more of the following applies:</b></p> <ul style="list-style-type: none"> <li>• Leaders are taking action to improve the achievement of prisoners, in particular those who face barriers to accessing and succeeding in education, skills and work. However, too many prisoners do not make the expected progress from their starting points, and for many, achievement rates are too low.</li> <li>• While many prisoners develop the knowledge, skills and behaviours they need to achieve the aims of the education, skills and work curriculum, too many do not and there are gaps in their knowledge.</li> <li>• Although there are examples of positive progression, too many prisoners do not develop their reading sufficiently well.</li> <li>• While some prisoners produce work in line with the standard expected for their level of study or work activity, too many do not.</li> <li>• While some prisoners are well equipped to progress to their next steps, too many are not, due to gaps in their knowledge, skills and behaviours.</li> </ul> | <p><b>Achievement meets the 'expected standard' when all the following apply:</b></p> <p>Prisoners, in particular those who face barriers to education, skills and work, typically make appropriate progress from their starting points. They largely achieve relevant qualifications within the anticipated timeframe.</p> <p>Prisoners generally develop the intended new knowledge, skills and behaviours as they progress through the curriculum/training programme, and can apply these effectively. They produce work of the standard expected for the level of course they are studying and/or their work role.</p> <p>Prisoners broadly develop the English, ESOL, mathematical and digital skills they need to study the curriculum/training plan and to achieve their learning and/or work goals. This includes making progress towards level 2 mathematics and English qualifications.</p> <p>Prisoners who have worked on their reading typically develop appropriate rates of new knowledge and skills. They generally progress to suitable next steps, such as work roles or education courses.</p> <p>Prisoners are usually ready for the next stage of education, employment or training. They typically go on to next steps that reflect their interests and</p> | <p><b>Achievement meets the 'strong standard' when the 'expected standard' has been met and all the following apply:</b></p> <p>Prisoners consistently make extensive progress from their starting points and/or achieve well. Achievement rates, where applicable, are high or have improved significantly, especially for those who face barriers to accessing and succeeding in education, skills and work.</p> <p>Prisoners develop a thorough and secure understanding of new concepts. They apply their academic, technical or vocational knowledge, skills and behaviours fluently and with confidence across education, skills and work.</p> <p>Prisoners produce theoretical and practical work that is of a consistently high standard.</p> <p>Prisoners who have worked on their reading develop high levels of new knowledge. They consistently progress to positive next steps, such as further study or work roles.</p> <p>Through the knowledge, skills and behaviours gained, prisoners are very well prepared for further study and/or training/employment, both in custody and following release. A significant proportion of those prisoners who are released from the establishment gain employment.</p> |

| Needs attention                                                                                                                                                                 | Expected standard                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                         | Strong standard                                                                      |
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| <ul style="list-style-type: none"> <li>While many prisoners achieve their personal targets and goals, too many do not and do not make the progress planned for them.</li> </ul> | <p>meet their work goals and aspirations, both in custody and on release.</p> <p>Prisoners achieve their personal targets and goals. This helps them to, for example, build confidence, improve their health and wellbeing, prepare for further learning or employment, and improve essential skills.</p> | <p>Prisoners consistently achieve ambitious personal learning targets and goals.</p> |

## **Urgent improvement**

**Achievement is likely to be graded 'urgent improvement' when any of the following apply:**

- Prisoners do not develop the intended knowledge, skills and behaviours. They make very slow or minimal progress from starting points, and/or produce poor-quality work. Very few of those who remain at the establishment progress to positive next steps.
- Achievement rates for prisoners are consistently low and show little improvement.
- Prisoners cannot progress in their courses, qualifications or workplaces because they do not gain the English, mathematical or digital skills and knowledge they need.
- Prisoners who have worked on their reading make little or no progress.
- Prisoners with barriers to education, skills and work make very limited or no progress. The support provided is not effective in helping them achieve their goals.
- Prisoners do not develop the personal, social and employability skills they need to progress. As a result, they are poorly prepared for future employment and/or further learning, both in custody and on release.

## Exceptional

**Inspectors may consider leaders' work in achievement to be 'exceptional' when the 'strong standard' has been met and all the following apply:**

The vast majority of prisoners develop exceptionally high levels of subject knowledge and skill in relation to their starting points, in particular those prisoners with specific barriers to accessing and succeeding in education, skills and work. This is demonstrated in the theoretical and practical work they produce.

Leaders' actions have a transformational impact on the readiness of prisoners for their future careers and/or study pathways, both in custody and on release. All groups of prisoners progress to positive next steps, including those released from the establishment.

There are no significant areas for improvement that leaders have not already prioritised.

**If this grade is awarded, leaders should use their exceptional success in this evaluation area to:**

- support improvement across all aspects of their own provision and/or group
- share their learning and best practice externally to support system-wide improvement, for example with other prisons, professionals, their community and stakeholders, including local and/or national networks.

# Participation and development

This evaluation area considers:

- how leaders ensure that prisoners are supported to attend and participate well in their studies and work activities, including those who face barriers to accessing and succeeding in education, skills and work
- the support that prisoners receive to develop and demonstrate appropriate professional and prosocial behaviours in their studies/training and/or when at work
- how leaders create a learning environment that supports prisoners with their studies and work activities, ensuring that they meet the principles and requirements of the course or work activity that leaders are providing
- the support that prisoners receive to help them plan their next steps
- how the curriculum supports prisoners' wider development and wellbeing, ensuring that they engage, achieve and thrive

Inspectors focus on the factors that statutory and non-statutory guidance, research and inspection evidence indicate contribute most strongly to participation and development, thereby giving prisoners the greatest possible opportunity to develop a broad array of skills and knowledge that prepare them well for living and working in modern Britain.

These factors are:

- providing prisoners with welcoming environments for study and work, where bullying, unlawful discrimination, harassment, victimisation, physical and/or sexual violence, and derogatory language are not tolerated
- ensuring that prisoners are supported to attend regularly and participate in their studies and work activities, and that they are encouraged and supported to improve their attendance and participation when needed
- supporting prisoners to demonstrate appropriate behaviours both in their studies and when at work, and dealing with inappropriate behaviour swiftly and consistently
- providing prisoners with age-appropriate opportunities that help them to understand how to stay healthy and safe, and to develop their personal skills
- ensuring that prisoners are prepared well for life in modern Britain through developing an understanding of fundamental British values and diversity, and respect for protected characteristics
- providing prisoners with appropriate careers education and guidance to help them make informed choices about their next steps, both in custody and on release
- ensuring that prisoners develop appropriate employability skills and, where relevant, skills for independent living

# Considering participation and development in different types of prison

When inspectors evaluate participation and development across different types of prison, they consider the context of the education, skills and work curriculum the prison offers and the nature of the prisoners, for example:

- the age-appropriateness and relevance of topics covered during personal development or similar activities
- the potential for specific groups of prisoners to engage in their wider development, depending, for example, on the length of time spent at the prison
- the focus of careers education and guidance in different prison and prisoner contexts, including ensuring that prisoners accurately understand how their criminal records might affect future work and career prospects, will vary. Prisoners serving long sentences will need a greater focus on work and education opportunities in custody, whereas guidance for those who are preparing for release will likely focus on careers and work opportunities available in the community and producing appropriate disclosure letters
- the work done at the prison, if relevant, with prisoners who need to improve their behaviour, attitudes to learning or attendance
- the promotion of equality of opportunity so that prisoners feel welcome and understand that individual characteristics make people unique; this includes, but is not limited to, an age-appropriate understanding of the protected characteristics defined by the Equality Act 2010

# Gathering evidence about participation and development

## Strategic leadership of participation and development

In gathering evidence about the strategic leadership of participation and development, inspectors evaluate the extent to which leaders:

- set and embed clear expectations for prisoners' attendance, behaviour and personal responsibility across education, skills and work
- provide prisoners with access to a suitable range of opportunities beyond their taught courses or work that help them to build confidence, resilience and personal skills
- take strategic and proactive steps to support prisoners to engage fully in their studies, work activities and wider development

## Attendance, behaviour and participation

In gathering evidence about attendance, behaviour and participation, inspectors evaluate the extent to which:

- leaders and staff promote and reinforce high expectations for attendance, punctuality and participation for all prisoners, in particular those who face barriers to education, skills and work
- prisoners have high attendance levels at their education, skills or work activity, or improve their attendance quickly and sustainably
- prisoners behave appropriately, maintain high standards in their training and/or workplace settings, and are supported by teachers, trainers and instructors to do so
- prisoners participate in scheduled learning/training sessions and work activities

## Wider opportunities

In gathering evidence about wider opportunities, inspectors evaluate (as applicable to the context of the prison) the extent to which:

- prisoners take part in tailored wider development and enrichment activities that prepare them well for employment or further study, in particular those who face barriers to education, skills and work
- prisoners develop their understanding of mental, physical and emotional health, how to protect themselves from radicalisation and extremist views, healthy relationships and online safety, through content that is appropriate to their age
- prisoners develop their understanding of fundamental British values, the protected characteristics, diversity and respect for all citizens, and can apply this in their learning, work and interactions with others
- prisoners, as appropriate, make a positive contribution to their communities or support the wider development of others
- prisoners, in particular those with a long stay at the prison/YOI, develop an interest in reading for pleasure

## Prisoners' preparation for their next steps and release

In gathering evidence about prisoners' preparation for their next steps, inspectors evaluate the extent to which:

- leaders provide an induction programme so that prisoners understand the range of progression routes available to them, and can make informed decisions about their future learning, employment and/or training
- leaders provide prisoners with structured, tailored careers education and guidance that reflects their interests, aspirations and potential next steps, both in custody and on release
- prisoners develop the personal attributes they need for their intended job roles, further study or, where appropriate, for greater independence and/or care-giving responsibilities
- prisoners, in particular those who face barriers to education, skills and work, are supported to explore and plan for progression from their current role or course and they feel confident and well prepared to take their next steps, both in custody and on release

## Dealing with bullying, unlawful discrimination, harassment and victimisation

In gathering evidence about dealing with bullying, unlawful discrimination, harassment and victimisation, inspectors evaluate the extent to which:

- leaders and staff create a safe, welcoming and respectful education, skills and work environment for all prisoners, in particular those who face barriers to education, skills and work
- bullying, unlawful discrimination, harassment and victimisation are not accepted or normalised in education, skills and work
- prisoners know how to report concerns and are confident that staff will take them seriously and act promptly
- staff consistently recognise and address inappropriate language, attitudes and behaviour
- leaders monitor incidents and concerns relating to education, skills and work, and take strategic action to address patterns and underlying issues

## Inclusive participation and development

In gathering evidence about inclusive participation and development, inspectors evaluate the extent to which:

- prisoners feel welcome, valued and respected
- prisoners understand, appreciate and respect diversity
- prisoners respect the protected characteristics defined by the Equality Act 2010
- prisoners have opportunities to develop a range of professional and social skills for life in modern Britain, for example by working productively with others from different backgrounds to their own

## Grading participation and development

| Needs attention                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                          | Expected standard                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                    | Strong standard                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                        |
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| <p><b>Participation and development are likely to be graded 'needs attention' when the 'expected standard' has not been met.</b></p> <p><b>This may include when one or more of the following applies:</b></p> <ul style="list-style-type: none"> <li>• Leaders understand the importance of attendance, but their work to identify and tackle low attendance and/or barriers to attendance is inconsistent and lacks focus. As a result, attendance for some groups of prisoners is low, and/or shows limited or unsustained improvement, which hinders their progress.</li> <li>• Leaders have suitable expectations of prisoners' behaviour and attitudes, but staff lack the confidence and/or skills to manage incidents of poor behaviour. This can cause disruptions to learning, training and work, and slows prisoners' progress.</li> <li>• Leaders have established a curriculum for wider development, but this does not consider closely enough the needs of prisoners, in particular those who face barriers to accessing and succeeding in education, skills and work. As such, they do not benefit from a suitably broad curriculum for wider development to help them build personal skills.</li> </ul> | <p><b>Participation and development meet the 'expected standard' when all the following apply:</b></p> <p>Leaders typically ensure that prisoners study, train and/or work in safe, welcoming and respectful environments where their wellbeing is prioritised, particularly those prisoners with specific barriers to learning, work and/or wellbeing.</p> <p>Leaders set high expectations for the attendance, behaviours and attitudes of prisoners. Prisoners typically behave appropriately, attend well and arrive punctually to education, skills and work activities. They are respectful towards their peers and staff.</p> <p>Leaders identify the reasons why certain prisoners do not attend or participate regularly, particularly those with specific barriers to accessing education, skills and work. Leaders' actions support prisoners to engage or re-engage with their studies and/or work.</p> <p>Leaders do not tolerate bullying, unlawful discrimination, harassment, victimisation, physical and/or sexual violence, or derogatory or aggressive language in education, skills and work. Staff address any inappropriate behaviour consistently and promptly. Prisoners know how to raise issues and are confident that staff will take them seriously.</p> | <p><b>Participation and development meet the 'strong standard' when the 'expected standard' has been met and all the following apply:</b></p> <p>Leaders foster an inclusive education, skills and work culture in which diversity is celebrated, equality of opportunity is promoted, and social equity is actively pursued. This has a significant positive impact on prisoners from all backgrounds. They feel highly valued and respected.</p> <p>Incidents of bullying, unlawful discrimination, harassment, victimisation, physical and/or sexual violence and derogatory language are rare. When they do occur, they are dealt with consistently and highly effectively.</p> <p>Leaders' consistent and persistent focus on attendance and participation has had a sustained positive impact on prisoners. Staff contribute to a culture in which high attendance and participation by all groups of prisoners are expected, valued and routinely achieved.</p> <p>Prisoners are highly motivated, show a strong commitment to their studies and are proud of the work they produce. They collaborate respectfully with their peers, contribute positively to the learning environment, and</p> |

| Needs attention                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                             | Expected standard                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                        | Strong standard                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                |
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| <ul style="list-style-type: none"> <li>Although leaders have developed a curriculum that focuses on mental and physical health, healthy relationships, and protection from radicalisation and extremist views, it is not matched well with prisoners' ages or needs.</li> <li>Staff teach prisoners about protected characteristics, fundamental British values and cultural diversity in modern Britain, and they challenge any prejudiced views or comments, but this is not undertaken in a way that deepens understanding. As a result, prisoners struggle to apply these values or recognise their relevance in daily life or work.</li> <li>Leaders have offered careers education and guidance to prisoners, but this is often unstructured, poorly targeted and/or lacks detail. They do not give some groups of prisoners sufficient information and support to help them make informed choices, for example through the induction programme. Prisoners' preparedness for future work opportunities, both in custody and on release, is underdeveloped.</li> </ul> | <p>Leaders generally understand prisoners' wider development needs. They provide suitable opportunities for prisoners to take part in activities that develop personal attributes such as resilience, confidence and independence.</p> <p>The curriculum includes age-appropriate content about mental and physical health, healthy relationships, and how to protect oneself from radicalisation and extremist views. Prisoners develop an appropriate understanding of these topics, and they generally know how to stay safe and make informed choices about their wellbeing.</p> <p>Prisoners typically develop their understanding of, and respect for, protected characteristics, fundamental British values and cultural diversity in modern Britain. Staff address prejudiced views or comments.</p> <p>Leaders provide an effective induction programme. Prisoners understand clearly the range of progression routes available to them and can make informed decisions to prepare for the future, both in custody and on release.</p> <p>Prisoners, including those with barriers to education, skills and work, receive suitable careers education and tailored guidance. On the whole, this helps them to make informed decisions about their next steps and challenges any misconceptions or stereotypes they may hold about careers. It typically includes, where relevant, direct links to employers.</p> | <p>demonstrate high levels of professionalism in work roles.</p> <p>Leaders provide prisoners with a rich and carefully tailored offer of wider opportunities, which develops prisoners' personal attributes and helps them take a more active role in their own lives. They demonstrate strong personal and social responsibility, for example by contributing to their communities.</p> <p>Leaders and staff expertly embed across the curriculum an understanding of and respect for fundamental British values, protected characteristics and cultural diversity. Prisoners confidently apply their understanding in lessons, work roles and community engagement.</p> <p>Leaders and staff skilfully embed high-quality careers education and guidance throughout the curriculum, including support for those wishing to become self-employed and, where relevant, successful links to employers. Through a highly effective induction programme, prisoners develop detailed knowledge of their potential future pathways and are confident in knowing how to take their next steps.</p> <p>Prisoners who face barriers to accessing and succeeding in education, skills and work receive tailored, impactful support and guidance, which prepare them very well for future learning, employment and/or independence.</p> |

| Needs attention | Expected standard                                                                                                                          | Strong standard |
|-----------------|--------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|-----------------|
|                 | Leaders support prisoners, in particular those with a long stay at the prison, to develop an interest in reading and to read for pleasure. |                 |

## Urgent improvement

**Participation and development are likely to be graded 'urgent improvement' when any of the following apply:**

- Bullying, unlawful discrimination, harassment and/or victimisation across education, skills and work are commonplace and not addressed properly. Prisoners feel unsupported and lack trust in leaders to handle their concerns, leading to under-reporting.
- Leaders have not established a culture that encourages and supports high attendance and participation across education, skills and work. They do not take actions that help prisoners to overcome their barriers to attendance. As a result, attendance is low and shows little sign of sustained improvement.
- Prisoners behave inappropriately and are not challenged or do not respond to requests to modify their behaviour.
- Prisoners are not taught the knowledge they need to build healthy relationships or protect themselves from radicalisation and extremist views. As a result, they are unsure how to respond to risks or make safe choices.
- Leaders have not ensured that prisoners receive careers education and guidance and/or induction to education, skills and work. As a result, prisoners cannot make informed decisions about their future, either in custody or on release.

## Exceptional

**Inspectors may consider leaders' work in participation and development to be 'exceptional' when the 'strong standard' has been met and all the following apply:**

Leaders' focus on participation and development has a transformational impact on prisoners from all backgrounds, such as transformations in their views and attitudes.

Leaders' highly focused work on attendance results in all groups of prisoners attending their education, skills and work activities at very high rates over a sustained period.

There are no significant areas for improvement that leaders have not already prioritised.

**If this grade is awarded, leaders should use their exceptional success in this evaluation area to:**

- support improvement across all aspects of their own provision and/or group
- share their learning and best practice externally to support system-wide improvement, for example with other prisons, professionals, their community and stakeholders, including local and/or national networks